

FAST FOOD

ISHAN TANKHA



NO KIDDING: India is among the top 10 most-frequent consumers of fast food in the world

ity, India's young, high-spending, globally-connected yuppies are biting into French fries and burgers with relish. It's a way of asserting a new economic identity. "Cultural liberation has two sides," adds Kapoor, "good and bad. India is a huge market and the multinationals know that. The mantra is marketing—carpet bombing of print and electronic media—so that what is seen more sells more. Then it becomes a style statement." Unlike in the West, fast food in India is a compelling attraction for the affluent and upwardly mobile.

Step into the airconditioned interior, get in line, study the backlit menu board, place your order, watch youngsters in uniforms pushing buttons, take your plastic tray of food wrapped in paper. A "slice of America" that is India's now. "Quick and easy is the name of the game in today's kitchens," says Kapoor. Consider this: in a 2007 AC Nielsen survey, 62 per cent mentioned unhealthy, convenient food as "ideal snacks", while 50 per cent held fast foods to be "light yet filling" and "convenient". Paroma Banerjee, a 40-year-old market researcher in Kolkata, is not surprised: "With a 70-hour work-week, an equally busy husband and a 10-year-old at home, you end up eating much more ready-food than you actually want to."

So much so, that India is among the top 10 most-frequent consumers of fast food in the world. The top 50 per cent consume 80 per cent fast food in a market that is Rs 40,000 crore-strong and growing at a robust 40 per cent annually. Over 100 million spend close to \$1 billion (Rs 4,000 crore) annually on fast food. No wonder global chains are reinventing themselves and expanding networks for India. If McDonald's offers the McAloo Tikka, at Pizza Hut it is chicken tikka masala toppings. If KFC plans 1,000 restaurants by 2014, Subway is gearing up to invest over \$40 million. Homegrown chains like Pizza Corner, Nirulas, Haldiram's and Not Just Paranthas are also growing in strength.

Sadly, it's not a "revolution" for a better world. As high-calorie, over-processed foods swallow up larger portions of Middle India's platter and pocket, obesity, diabetes, coronary diseases, cancer stalk the nation. Some, however, see a silver lining. Indian cuisine has always borrowed exotic ingredients and been modified by external influences, say food historians. "Even tandoori food was not always popular,"

writes Julie Sahni, food columnist with *The New York Times*. "In 1947, when the first tandoori restaurant opened in India, it was labelled low-class." Take heart. Perhaps fast food, too, will run its course and become another entry on the nation's menu card one day. ■

S.N. GADHOKE, fast food chain investor, 1985

"The money lies in how quickly you can get people past the counter. Volume is the key."